

IMO climate talks stall as shipping deal deadline looms

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By Martina Sapio · Sep 4, 2026, 4:57 PM · [View in your browser](#)

After a week of talks on the International Maritime Organization's contested shipping climate deal, governments failed to make headway on the main sticking points, with a December deadline for agreement looming.

A status update, circulated on the final day of talks Friday and obtained by POLITICO, shows there is still no agreed base text for several major and controversial parts of the proposed Net-Zero Framework . These include how the U.N. shipping agency would run a central fund financed by higher-emitting ships; how those charges would be set after 2031; how ships' fuel emissions and compliance would be tracked; and how vessels using the cleanest fuels would be rewarded.

With the September discussions now over, negotiators have only a few months left before the window for new proposals effectively closes, Felix Klann, shipping policy officer at NGO Transport & Environment, said. The next session at which countries can actually vote will be in December, making it the de facto deadline for a deal.

"We have a couple of months left, and we still don't really have a compromise," Klann warned.

A transport sector representative in the room, granted anonymity to speak candidly about closed-door talks, said negotiators spent the week testing compromise after compromise, only to keep coming back to the same basic disagreements — even if there was some movement on smaller issues.

Klann, who also followed the talks from inside the room, concurred. "Ultimately, we haven't moved very far," he said.

During the talks, IMO Chair Harry Conway floated possible landing zones, including a slower pace of emissions cuts in the early years, regular reviews and closer checks on whether cleaner fuels are actually available, according to the transport representative. Several governments also showed growing interest in giving ships extra credit for using cleaner fuels.

But by the end of the week, Conway acknowledged that while countries were willing to move forward, many issues remained unresolved, the transport representative said. No single compromise drew enough support to become the basis for agreement.

Saudi Arabia was among the clearest opponents of the proposed framework. In a joint paper with Kuwait, also obtained by POLITICO, Riyadh said the chair had focused too heavily on tweaking the deal already on the table and had not sufficiently reflected the IMO's mandate to consider other approaches.

The U.S. also opposed the framework's financial machinery, but without the harsher diplomatic fireworks that accompanied last year's talks. Washington's delegates said they would not support any compliance system requiring payments, financing for an IMO fund or contributions to IMO-backed projects.

They did, however, see some merit in Japan's public-private partnership idea, which would allow ships to put money directly into IMO-approved clean-shipping projects involving private-sector investment, rather than via a central fund.

European governments signaled they were ready to accept some flexibility without abandoning the proposed global shipping climate rules.

Greece, whose position has been somewhat ambiguous in recent months despite signing onto the EU's common position, struck a conciliatory note as the talks wound down Friday, saying differences remained, but it was open to all proposals consistent with the IMO's 2023 climate strategy. Malta aligned with Athens, and Italy backed this approach too, while stressing pragmatism, the transport representative said. Cyprus said it was open to further bilateral talks.

Klann noted that those showing interest in compromise — including the EU — were largely the countries already willing to engage, while talks remained stuck on the same “fundamental opposition” from a small group of oil-producing countries and the U.S.

A fresh status update expected in the coming days to capture where negotiations now stand.

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